Damodara Pandita

Дамодара Пандит (Дамодара Брахмачари) · @damodara-pandita

The Brahmachari of Navadvipa

His name was Damodara Pandita, and he was also called Damodara Brahmachari: he kept the vow of celibacy, and the Lord Himself, speaking of him, called him a brahmachari (CC, Madhya 7.25). He was a brahmana of Navadvipa. Murari Gupta, telling his poem about the Lord, addresses him as “the brahmana Damodara” and “the best of brahmanas.”

Who he was in Vraja is revealed by Kavi Karnapura:

“Shaibya, who in Vraja was known for her fiery temper, is Damodara Pandita; for a certain purpose the goddess Sarasvati also entered into him.” (GGD 159)

The word Karnapura uses for her temper is *chandi*, “sharp, formidable”[1]. That one word says the main thing about Damodara in Sri Chaitanya's pastimes as well: none of the associates spoke to the Lord as directly as he did. In the same place Karnapura names his younger brother, Shankara Pandita, as Sri Bhadra (GGD 157), and Pitambara, of whom more below, as Kaveri (GGD 168).

Krishnadasa Kaviraja, listing the branches of Sri Chaitanya's tree, gives him the tenth place — and at once says what he is remembered for:

“The tenth branch is Sri Damodara Pandita. He had such great love for Sri Chaitanya that once he even rebuked Him.” (CC, Adi 10.31)

“I shall tell of this in more detail later. Fully pleased with this reproach, Sri Chaitanya sent Damodara to Navadvipa.” (CC, Adi 10.32)

“The eleventh branch is Shankara Pandita, Damodara's younger brother. Everyone also called him Prabhu-padopadhana (the pillow for the Lord's feet).” (CC, Adi 10.33)

The love that dares to reproach the Lord Himself the “Charitamrita” calls *prachanda*, “impetuous.” In the language of the Vaishnavas such a reproach is *vakya-danda*, “chastisement by word.” It is neither impudence nor self-assurance: the Lord Himself willed this pastime and was Himself “fully pleased” with it. Krishnadasa recalls it in the brief summaries of his book too: after the Lord punished Junior Haridasa, “Damodara Pandita tried to correct the Lord's behaviour” (Madhya 1.259); the third chapter of the Antya-lila tells how “Damodara Pandita boldly tried to rebuke the Lord” (Antya 20.106).

Kavi Karnapura in the “Chaitanya-chandrodaya-nataka” names Damodara and Shankara among the beloved associates, “His own since childhood,” who descended to the earth together with the Lord to deliver the world (1.25). Of his family the “Charitamrita” knows only one thing: Shankara was his younger brother. Later traditions say more. In the “Vaishnava-vandana” Devakinandana praises “Damodara Pandita, the most dispassionate, and Pitambara, his elder brother by birth,” and the Sanskrit vandana names five brothers “free from desires” — Damodara, Pitambara, Jagannatha, Shankara and Narayana. Lochana Dasa may be speaking of the same: “Together with Damodara Pandita, five brothers took birth on earth in one place” (“Chaitanya-mangala,” Sutra-khanda, pt. 8, v. 630)[2].

Damodara's Questions

The first biography of Sri Chaitanya, Murari Gupta's Sanskrit poem “Sri Krishna-chaitanya-charitamrita,” owes its existence to Damodara Pandita. The whole of it is a dialogue: Damodara asks, Murari tells. Murari brings him into the poem with love:

“Hearing of this wonder, the brahmachari Sri Damodara Pandita, master of his senses and intoxicated with the stories of Sri Chaitanya, said: ‘Tell the divine and wondrous story that purifies the world… For what reason was He, the all-powerful Lord of all, born on earth? What did He, the Lord of the worlds, accomplish here?’” (Murari, 1.2.15–18)

With this question — why the Lord came — the narrative begins. And after it Damodara's questions, like milestones, open one part of the poem after another. “Tell us, then, the story of Nrihari,” he asks, and Murari speaks of the Lord's descents (1.4.1). He asks to hear of Vishvarupa, the Lord's elder brother (1.7.1). “What pastimes did the Lord, the treasury of pastimes, perform in Navadvipa?” — so the second part of the poem opens (2.1.1). He wishes to hear of the wondrous form of the Lord revealed in a dream (2.9.1); of how the Lord accepted sannyasa, wandered and came to Purushottama (3.1.1); of how He beheld the Lord Purushottama (3.11.1). Murari calls his listener “the best of brahmanas,” “the great soul,” “a man of great power.”

Damodara does not only listen — he also argues. When Murari told how little Vishvambhara said to His mother, “I am going. Guard the body of your son…” — and fell senseless to the ground, and on reviving shone again with His natural light, Damodara could not accept it in silence:

“What is this you have told, good friend? Krishna Himself, the teacher of the world, was born here — how then could He say to His mother, ‘I am going; guard your son, good lady’? About this I have a great doubt. Is this the yogamaya of the Lord of the world? Please explain it — for the deeds of Hari are done for the good of the world.” (Murari, 1.7.25–27)

Yogamaya is the Lord's internal energy, by which He Himself reveals and conceals Himself in His pastimes; it is not the external maya, and the Lord is not subject to it. Murari, having reflected and bowed to Hari, replied: when a person meditates on Bhagavan, sings of Him and hears of Him, Hari enters the heart of that great soul, and he, forgetting his own body, bears within him His splendour and might; so the Lord taught the world that He regards the devotee's body as His own (1.8.1–7). Another time, hearing that at Bhubaneshvara the Lord had reverently eaten the remnants of offerings to Shiva, Damodara objected: because of Bhrigu's curse they are not eaten — how then could Bhagavan, knowing this, accept them? Murari explained: Mahadeva joyfully offered Krishna hospitality; and when people worship Maheshvara, regarding him as the best of Vaishnavas, the Lord accepts what they offer, and such food purifies (3.9.8–21).

And when the poem was finished, Damodara bowed to Murari:

“I have reached my goal, I have reached my goal, I have reached my goal — of this there is no doubt! Blessed are you, who fill hearts with the rasa of Krishna Chaitanya!” (Murari, 4.26.24)

Lochana Dasa kept the same frame. Opening the “Chaitanya-mangala,” he praises “Pandita Damodara” together with Rupa, Sanatana and Raghava Pandita (Sutra-khanda, pt. 1, v. 30) and names his source:

“All that the Lord did from His birth in childhood, how from beginning to end He spread prema — about all this Damodara Pandita questioned him, and he told him everything from beginning to end in due order. So came about a book of Gauranga's deeds composed in verse — the dialogue with Damodara, issued from Murari's mouth. Hearing it, I was filled with love, and I tell of Gaura's deeds in a sung narrative, a panchali.” (“Chaitanya-mangala,” Sutra-khanda, pt. 1, vv. 53–56)

He repeats it at the end of the Madhya-khanda: Murari told it in verses, “Pandita Sri Damodara asked him”; “what I have heard is by the grace of them both” (Madhya-khanda, pt. 22, vv. 252–253).

In Lochana too the talks of the two friends sound alive. “I make one request — it is a long-standing pain in my heart… where did Vishvarupa, the Thakura's brother, go?” asks Damodara, and Murari replies, “Listen, listen, Damodara, foremost of pandits” (Adi-khanda, pt. 5, vv. 423–426). He asks what

Vishvambhara's motionless body meant — “Did the Lord display His yogamaya, or some power?” — and Murari explains that the Lord regards the devotee's body as His own (Adi-khanda, pt. 8, vv. 630–652). And having heard the answer about Shiva's prasada, Damodara exclaims, “Now the knot is untied!” (Madhya-khanda, pt. 21, vv. 96–110). According to one of the biographies, Lochana Dasa says that Damodara himself passed Murari's verses on to him and told him about the Lord; the “Chaitanya-mangala” says nothing of the kind[3].

Navadvipa

In Navadvipa Damodara was beside the Lord in the years of kirtana. When the Lord returned from Gaya and His associates gathered around Him, Lochana Dasa names among them “Rudra Pandita and Pandita Damodara” (“Chaitanya-mangala,” Madhya-khanda, pt. 1, v. 60). A pada signed with the name Yadu sings that Damodara sang in the Lord's night kirtana in Navadvipa.

When the Lord left Navadvipa and accepted sannyasa, “Sri Chandrashekhara Acharya, Pandita Damodara, Vakreshvara and others” hastened after Him to Katwa (“Chaitanya-mangala,” Madhya-khanda, pt. 16, v. 43). Karnapura in the “Chaitanya-chandrodaya-nataka” gives the lament of the devotees for the departed Lord: Jagadananda falls senseless, and Damodara cries out, “O Lord of my life! Where are You, where are You?” (Act 4). In a pada of Vasu Ghosha mourning the sannyasa his name is heard too: “How will Gadadhara and Damodara live?”

The Road to Nilachala

From Katwa Nityananda cleverly brought the Lord to Shantipura, to the house of Advaita Acharya. All the people of Navadvipa came there, and Damodara with them:

“Srivasa, Ramai, Vidyanidhi, Gadadhara, Gangadasa, Vakreshvara, Murari and Shuklambara were there.” (CC, Madhya 3.153)

“Buddhimanta Khan, Nandana, Shridhara, Vijaya, Vasudeva, Damodara, Mukunda and Sanjaya.” (CC, Madhya 3.154)

The Lord stayed in Shantipura ten days. His mother asked Him to settle in Puri so that she could receive news of Him, and He agreed. Then Advaita gave Him companions:

“Nityananda, Jagadananda Pandita, Damodara Pandita and Mukunda Datta.” (CC, Madhya 3.209)

“Sri Advaita asked these four to accompany Lord Chaitanya to Puri. Mahaprabhu comforted His mother and offered prayers at her feet.” (CC, Madhya 3.210)[4]

The “Charitamrita” says that Nityananda, Jagadananda, Damodara and Mukunda were beside themselves with joy at having the Lord's company (Madhya 1.100)[5].

One of the biographies traces their road: Atisara, Panihati, Baranagar[6], Vriddha-Mantreshvara on the border of Utkala, and Remuna, where the companions saw Kshirachora-Gopinatha and heard the Lord tell of Madhavendra Puri. According to the “Charitamrita,” the Lord went through Chhatrabhoga (Madhya 3.216) and Remuna (Madhya 4.10–19). In Puri, on seeing Jagannatha, the Lord lost consciousness, and Sarvabhauma Bhattacharya carried Him to his own house. The four companions, coming after Him to the Lion Gate, learned where the Lord was and went there too.

According to one of the biographies, the Lord accepted sannyasa in the bright fortnight of the month of Magha, came to Puri in Phalguna, granted His mercy to Sarvabhauma in Chaitra, and left for the South in Vaishakha.

Sarvabhauma's Two Verses

Sarvabhauma was an unrivalled master of logic and an interpreter of Vedanta in the spirit of Mayavada. By the Lord's mercy he gave up his former arguments and became so pure a devotee that, as one of the biographies says, he could no longer utter the word “mukti” and said “bhakti” instead. Once he went for darshana of Jagannatha together with Jagadananda and Damodara, and on returning home gave them maha-prasada for the Lord (CC, Madhya 6.248–249). With them he also sent a palm leaf bearing two verses about the Lord:

“On a palm leaf Sarvabhauma wrote two verses and gave it to Jagadananda, asking him to deliver it to Sri Chaitanya. Jagadananda went to Mahaprabhu with the prasada and this palm leaf. Mukunda Datta took the leaf from Jagadananda's hands. Then Mukunda copied the verses onto the wall at the entrance of the room, and after that gave the leaf to Sri Chaitanya. As soon as the Lord read these verses, He at once tore up the leaf; but the devotees read them on the wall before Mahaprabhu's room and kept them in their hearts.” (CC, Madhya 6.250–253)

The first glorifies the Lord who came as Sri Chaitanya to teach renunciation, knowledge and devotion to Himself; the second, the Lord who revived the path of love for Himself, almost lost over the ages (Madhya 6.254–255). Ever since, these two verses have been “the strings of pearls on the necks of all Mahaprabhu's devotees” (6.256)[7].

Karnapura in the “Chaitanya-chandrodaya-nataka” makes Damodara one of the living participants of those days. He and Jagadananda are with the Lord when Sarvabhauma first receives Him in his house; at the Lord's word he leads Gopinatha Acharya away to be fed with maha-prasada; it is he who announces to Gopinatha the change in Sarvabhauma with the verse “Without a pen the Lord has bound the mighty wild elephant…”: the heart of this lord of panditas, “harder than a thunderbolt,” the Lord has made as juicy as nectar; and it is the two of them who, “hastily throwing back the curtain,” come in to the Lord with the words: “Master! The Bhattacharya has sent two verses and alms-food — the remnants of Lord Jagannatha's meal” (Act 6).

“The Staff of Instruction”

In the spring of that same year the Lord resolved to go to the South — to search, as He said, for Vishvarupa (Madhya 7.11) — and to go alone. Nityananda and the others could not reconcile themselves to the separation, and Nityananda pleaded with Him to take at least one companion. Then the Lord, as if excusing Himself, listed the “faults” of His intimates: each of them, He said, in his own way held Him in hand. Damodara's turn came too:

“I am a sannyasi, and Damodara is a brahmachari, yet he always tries to instruct Me with a stick in his hand.” (CC, Madhya 7.25)

“In his view I do not know the rules of proper conduct, and so he constantly tries to restrain My wilful nature.” (CC, Madhya 7.26)

“By Krishna's mercy he does not care for public opinion, but I must always conform to people's notions of a sannyasi's duty, and therefore I cannot disregard it.” (CC, Madhya 7.27)

The “staff of instruction” is *shiksha-danda*: by rule it is the sannyasi who carries the staff, yet here the brahmachari seems to hold a stick over the sannyasi. But Krishnadasa Kaviraja at once reveals what stands behind these “reproaches”:

“The Lord is always conquered by the virtues of His devotees. Seemingly mentioning their faults, He was in truth relishing all these qualities.” (CC, Madhya 7.29)

One of the biographies observes that with these words the Lord subtly pointed to Damodara's chief trait — *nirapeksha*, freedom from regard for people and for one's own advantage. So, listing their imagined

faults, the Lord glorified Nityananda, Jagadananda and Damodara — and still went alone, taking with Him only a simple brahmana, Krishnadasa (Madhya 7.39–40).

The Lord's Return

For two years the devotees in Puri lived in separation. When the news came that the Lord was returning and had already reached Alalanatha, they could wait no longer:

“Hearing of Mahaprabhu's approach, Nityananda Raya at once hastened to meet Him, unable to bear the waiting because of the feelings of divine love that overflowed Him.” (CC, Madhya 9.339)

“Eager to see Sri Chaitanya, Jagadananda, Damodara Pandita and Mukunda danced with happiness, unable to master their feelings.” (CC, Madhya 9.340)

According to one of the biographies, the Lord, having reached Alalanatha, Himself sent His servant Krishnadasa ahead with the news, and the four ran out to meet Him on the high road.

That same Krishnadasa the Lord, on His return, decided to dismiss. He told Sarvabhauma that in the South the brahmana had been enticed by women of a Bhattathari camp and had left the Lord; the Lord had rescued him with difficulty and now did not wish him to remain with Him. Krishnadasa wept. Taking pity on him, the four friends found a service for him:

“Then a plan ripened in the minds of four devotees — Nityananda, Jagadananda, Mukunda and Damodara: ‘We must send someone to Bengal to tell Shachimata that Sri Chaitanya has arrived in Jagannatha Puri.’” (CC, Madhya 10.67–68)

“‘Hearing of Mahaprabhu's return, all the devotees headed by Advaita and Srivasa will surely come to see Him. We can send Krishnadasa to Bengal.’ With these words they gave him the assurance that he could still serve the Lord.” (CC, Madhya 10.69–70)

The next day they asked the Lord's permission, and He agreed (10.71–72). The news of the Lord's return gladdened mother Shachi, Advaita, Srivasa and all the Vaishnavas of Bengal. The biographies add that later Damodara Pandita himself came from Puri to Gauda and met Kala Krishnadasa there[8].

Shankara Pandita

The news Krishnadasa brought roused all Bengal: the devotees, headed by Advaita, set out for Nilachala. With them came Shankara Pandita, Damodara's younger brother, and the Lord, seeing him, said to the elder:

“Seeing Shankara, Sri Chaitanya addressed Damodara Pandita: ‘My love for you is imbued with the deepest reverence.’” (CC, Madhya 11.146)

“‘Therefore take charge of your brother, Shankara, for I am bound to him by ties of pure and unmixed love.’” (CC, Madhya 11.147)

“Damodara replied: ‘Shankara is my younger brother, but since he has obtained Your mercy, he has become my elder brother.’” (CC, Madhya 11.148)

The Lord's love for Damodara is coloured by reverence (*gaurava*): the stern brahmachari is honoured by the Lord Himself. Towards Shankara, however, He feels a love that has no respectful distance, and therefore, as one of the biographies explains, He entrusts him to his elder brother, knowing that Damodara will keep him under discipline. In the last years Shankara became the Lord's inseparable servant: he slept beside Him, and the Lord at times fell asleep with His feet resting on him — hence he was called “the pillow for the Lord's feet.”

In those same days Nityananda, Jagadananda, Damodara and Mukunda joyfully met Haridasa Thakura, who had settled at Siddha-bakula (CC, Madhya 11.196). And when the Lord Himself began to serve prasada to the guests, no one would touch the food until He sat down; at Svarupa Damodara's request the Lord sat down to eat with Nityananda and the sannyasis, and then others took up the serving:

“After this Mahaprabhu sat down with all the sannyasis, and Gopinatha Acharya with great joy began to serve prasada.” (CC, Madhya 11.207)

“In jubilation Svarupa, Damodara Pandita and Jagadananda began to help him.” (CC, Madhya 11.208)

“If Damodara Says So”

Prataparudra, the king of Orissa, longed with all his heart to see the Lord and asked for a meeting more than once; when refused, he declared he would renounce his throne and live as a mendicant. Sarvabhauma, Nityananda and the others decided not to ask the Lord directly, but only to tell Him of the king's devotion. The Lord's heart softened, but He answered sternly — and referred to Damodara:

“‘You all want Me to go to Kataka to meet the king.’” (CC, Madhya 12.23)

“‘That will in no way raise Me spiritually, and besides, people will only laugh at Me! But why speak of people, when Damodara will shower Me with reproaches?’” (CC, Madhya 12.24)

“‘I will not meet the king, in spite of the requests of all the devotees. It is possible only if Damodara gives his consent.’” (CC, Madhya 12.25)

One of the biographies gives the interpretation of Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura in the “Amrita-pravaha-bhashya”: valuing Damodara's devotion, the Lord with these words gently hinted that his reproaches were sometimes superfluous and that he would do well to beware of this inclination. Damodara himself answered with loving pique (*abhimana*):

“‘You are the independent Supreme Lord,’ said Damodara. ‘You know perfectly well what should be done and what should not.’” (CC, Madhya 12.26)

“‘I am only a tiny soul — how can I instruct You? If You wish, You will meet the king, and I shall see it.’” (CC, Madhya 12.27)

“‘Prataparudra has love for You, and You always reciprocate with Your devotees. In reward for his love You will grant him Your touch.’” (CC, Madhya 12.28)

In this answer lies the essence of all his “strictness.” The Lord is wholly independent, and no one has the right to give Him rules; but by His very nature He is conquered by love (*sneha-vasha*), and so whoever loves Him, him He will surely accept. And so it came to pass.

Puri

At the Ratha-yatra the Lord divided the kirtana into seven groups. The first was led by Svarupa Damodara, Advaita Acharya danced in it, and five sang the responses:

“Svarupa Damodara He chose as the leader of the first group, and Mahaprabhu told five singers to sing the responses for him in the kirtana: Damodara, Narayana, Govinda Datta, Raghava Pandita and Sri Govindananda.” (CC, Madhya 13.36–37)

Karnapura in the “Chaitanya-charita-mahakavya” also names among the singers of the Ratha-yatra “Srila Damodara, the best of brahmanas” (15.105), and Lochana Dasa sees him dancing in the Lord's kirtana together with Gadadhara, Narahari, Nityananda, Srinivasa, Murari and Mukunda (“Chaitanya-mangala,” Madhya-khanda, pt. 22, v. 170). On the eve of the Ratha-yatra, after the cleansing of the Gundicha temple, the Lord held a feast in the garden, and Damodara Pandita was one of

the seven who served prasada:

“Seven devotees — Damodara Gosvami, Jagadananda, Damodara Pandita, Kashishvara, Gopinatha, Vaninatha and Shankara — served prasada to all, while the others joyfully cried, ‘Hari! Hari!’” (CC, Madhya 12.163)[9]

From then on he lived in Puri as one of the Lord's constant companions:

“Gadadhara Pandita, Vakreshvara, Damodara, Shankara and Haridasa Thakura remained to live with the Lord in Puri. Jagadananda, Bhagavan, Govinda, Kashishvara, Paramananda Puri and Svarupa Damodara also moved there.” (CC, Madhya 1.252–253)

The “Charitamrita” names him both among those who associated closely with the Lord in Puri (Adi 10.124–126) and among those with whom the Lord went every morning for darshana of Jagannatha — with Paramananda Puri, Jagadananda, Svarupa, Govinda and Kashishvara (Madhya 15.184–185). Once, together with Jagadananda, Svarupa, Govinda, Kashishvara, Shankara and Mukunda, he came to bathe in the ocean and heard from afar the singing of Junior Haridasa, who had already left his body (Antya 2.153–154). When Sanatana Gosvami came to Puri, the Lord introduced him to all His associates, Damodara Pandita among them (Antya 4.108–110); and at the feast given by Vallabha Bhatta, Damodara Pandita, with Svarupa, Jagadananda, Kashishvara, Shankara and Raghava, served prasada (Antya 7.66).

The Song-book

In the third year the devotees of Bengal came to Nilachala together with their wives. Having seen them off, the Lord resolved to go to Vrindavana by way of Bengal. Among those who left Puri with Him the “Charitamrita” names Damodara Pandita too (Madhya 16.127–129), and Karnapura names Govinda, Jagadananda, Sri Damodara Pandita and Paramananda Puri (“Chaitanya-charita-mahakavya” 19.6, 24).

Karnapura also preserved a small episode of this departure that is not in the “Charitamrita.” The evening before, the Lord said:

“I shall go, singing, to see Jagannatha, and this Damodara will surely sing together with Me.” (“Chaitanya-charita-mahakavya” 19.14)

At the end of the night the Lord set out with singing for the first service of the Lord of the temple; but Damodara was not at hand, and the Lord Himself waited for him for a while at the Lion Gate. At last he came:

“Then, a little late, that brahmana joined [them]; the Lord, His heart seized [by feeling], on seeing him grew angry. And He, the Ocean of love, out of love struck him many times on the back with the book of songs and kicked him.” (“Chaitanya-charita-mahakavya” 19.18–19)

Twice Karnapura repeats the word “love” — *pranayat pranayambudhih*, “out of love — the Ocean of love” — and this says everything: this is not the anger of a worldly man but the Lord's play of love with an eternal associate so dear to Him that He cannot sing without him. And at dawn Paramananda Puri, seeing the mark of the blow on Damodara's back, covered it with a cloth (19.30)[10].

That year the Lord, having pondered Sanatana's words, went only as far as Kanai-natashala and turned back without reaching Vrindavana. On the way back He stayed with Advaita in Shantipura, and returned to Nilachala with only two companions:

“‘I shall take only two with Me to Nilachala, and with the rest we shall meet at the Ratha-yatra.’” (CC, Madhya 1.235)

“So Balabhadra Bhattacharya and Damodara Pandita went with Sri Chaitanya to Puri.” (CC, Madhya 1.236)

And when the Lord, having travelled through Northern India and visited Vrindavana, returned with Balabhadra through the forests of Jharikhanda, the devotees came out to meet Him and met Him at Narendra-sarovara. The Lord bowed before the elders, and among those He embraced the “Charitamrita” names Damodara Pandita too (Madhya 25.218–222)[11].

The Widow's Son

Damodara's best-known vakya-danda, which the “Charitamrita” promised to tell of “later,” took place in Puri soon after the Lord rejected Junior Haridasa. In Purushottama there lived a boy, the son of a deceased brahmana of Orissa — well-mannered and very handsome. Every day he came to the Lord, bowed to Him and talked with Him at length, holding Him dearer than his own life, and the Lord was kind to him. Damodara could not accept this. Again and again he forbade the boy to come, but the boy could not live a day without seeing the Lord: “children are always drawn to where they are given love” (CC, Antya 3.7). And one day, when the boy had left, Damodara could restrain himself no longer:

“‘You instruct each and every one. You are the teacher even of other teachers. But we have yet to understand what kind of teacher You are.’” (CC, Antya 3.11)

“‘Now all over Jagannatha Puri everyone will be talking about You. What will become then of Your reputation as a teacher?’” (CC, Antya 3.12)[12]

He said it by hint, as if of someone else (*anyopadeshe*). The Lord asked, “What are you saying, Damodara?” — and he explained plainly:

“Damodara Pandita replied: ‘You are the independent Lord. You act as You Yourself wish, and no one can forbid You. But if people begin to discuss Your behaviour, how will You stop them?’” (CC, Antya 3.13–14)

“‘Lord! You are versed in all the scriptures. Why then do You not consider that this boy is the son of a brahmana widow? Why do You show him so much love?’” (CC, Antya 3.15)

“‘Though his mother, this brahmana widow, is austere, pious and chaste, she has one fault: she is young and beautiful. You too are very handsome and young. Why then do You give people such strong cause for gossip?’” (CC, Antya 3.16–17)

The Lord's response was unexpected:

“Having said this, Damodara Pandita fell silent. And Sri Chaitanya, inwardly pleased, began with a smile to reflect:” (CC, Antya 3.18)

“‘All these words of Damodara Pandita are born of the waves of pure love. Among all My closest friends there is no one who could compare with him.’” (CC, Antya 3.19)

What troubled Damodara was not the Lord's conduct — he himself acknowledges that the Lord is independent — but the talk of people, which might touch His name. For the Lord's honour he is ready to reproach the Lord Himself. That is why the Lord calls his reproach “a wave of pure love” and places him above all His intimates[13].

Guardian of Shachi's House

The next day the Lord called Damodara to a secluded place. With this conversation the “Charitamrita” explains its first words about him — “fully pleased with this reproach, Sri Chaitanya sent Damodara to Navadvipa”:

“Sri Chaitanya said: ‘O Damodara, My friend, I would like to ask you to go to Nadia and take care of My mother there.’” (CC, Antya 3.21)

“‘Apart from you I see no one who could look after her and protect her. You have surrounded even Me with your care.’” (CC, Antya 3.22)

“‘You are the most impartial friend among all My close associates. Without such objectivity it is impossible to protect the path of dharma from every attack.’” (CC, Antya 3.23)

“‘You can accomplish even what is beyond My power. You can rebuke even Me — what then to speak of others?’” (CC, Antya 3.24)

“‘Go to My mother's house and take shelter at her holy feet. In your presence no one will dare to behave as he pleases.’” (CC, Antya 3.25)

“‘From time to time you may come to see Me, but only for a short while, and then return again to Navadvipa.’” (CC, Antya 3.26)

“Impartiality” and “objectivity” in the translation stand for *nirapeksha*: freedom from regard for anyone whatsoever, without which, in the Lord's words, dharma cannot be protected[14].

The Lord told him to offer His mother millions of obeisances, to tell her about Him so as to console her heart, and to remind her of one secret: again and again He comes to her house and eats all that she offers Him. On the recent Magha-sankranti she had prepared various dishes and, offering them to Krishna, sat down to meditate; He came and quickly ate everything; wiping away her tears, she saw the empty tray and thought she had dreamt it, and in the confusion of separation decided she had not yet offered — and, finding the pots in the kitchen full, offered again (CC, Antya 3.27–37). And the Lord concluded:

“‘Thus again and again I ate all the offerings you made Me, attracted by your pure love. I live in Jagannatha Puri only in obedience to your instruction. Yet the power of your pure love draws Me so irresistibly that I am unable to resist.’” (CC, Antya 3.38–39)

The Lord gave Damodara Jagannatha's prasada — separately for His mother and for all the Vaishnavas — and he carried out exactly all that he had been told:

“So by the Lord's will Damodara Pandita was sent to Nadia (Navadvipa). After meeting Shachimata he remained to live at her holy feet.” (CC, Antya 3.42)

“He gave Jagannatha's prasada to all the Vaishnavas headed by Advaita Acharya. So Damodara Pandita did everything exactly as Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu had ordered him.” (CC, Antya 3.43)

In Navadvipa his strictness became a support for all:

“Everyone knew the strictness of Damodara Pandita, and therefore, out of fear of him, no one allowed himself any careless acts.” (CC, Antya 3.44)

“Damodara Pandita could rebuke anyone among Sri Chaitanya's associates in whom he saw a departure from proper conduct. So, by his strictness, he established the norms of proper behaviour for the Vaishnavas.” (CC, Antya 3.45)

“Thus I have told of the reproaches of Damodara Pandita. Hearing of them cleanses the heart of ignorance and godlessness.” (CC, Antya 3.46)

An echo of this account has apparently been kept in the “Gaura-krishnodaya” as well: the Lord, “restrained by words spoken by Svarupa,” sends to Navadvipa to comfort Shachi — whom, it does not say directly; in the course of the narrative it is Raghunatha Dasa, and the author has probably confused Damodara Pandita here with Svarupa Damodara (16.66). And Narahari Chakravarti in the “Bhakti-ratnakara” sees in him one of the four facets the Lord revealed to the world through His

associates: through Ramananda He showed victory over Kandarpa, through Haridasa — forbearance, through Sanatana and Rupa — humility, and "through Damodara He revealed impartiality" (1.630).

"Today You Have Bought Me"

As the Lord had allowed, Damodara came from time to time from Navadvipa to Puri. Vrindavana Dasa mentions that with the devotees of Bengal who went, headed by Advaita, to the Ratha-yatra, "Sri Damodara Pandita also returned to Nilachala, after visiting mother Shachi" (CB, Antya 8.37); Murari too names him in that procession — "Damodara Pandita and Raghunandana Thakura" (Murari, 4.17.12) — and the late "Vaishnava-vandana" says that Damodara, having seen Ai, hurried on (4.114).

Of one of these visits Vrindavana Dasa tells in detail. The Lord, seeing Damodara, called him to a secluded place and asked, "You have been staying with My mother. Tell Me the truth: is she devoted to Lord Vishnu?" (CB, Antya 9.91–93). And at this the stern brahmachari flared up:

"Hearing this question, the austere and impartial Damodara Pandita answered in anger:" (CB, Antya 9.94)

"'O Gosvami, what are You saying? You ask whether Your mother has devotion to God?'" (CB, Antya 9.95)

"'Your devotion to Lord Vishnu has come to You by the mercy of Your mother. All that You have has come through her.'" (CB, Antya 9.96)

"'Know that all the devotion You have has come to You by her mercy.'" (CB, Antya 9.97)

On her body, he went on, tears, trembling, perspiration, swoons and hair standing on end are always to be seen; the name of Krishna never leaves her lips; is it not she who is called Vishnu-bhakti? "You know this perfectly well, but You ask, pretending that You do not know"; and even one who utters "Ai," "mother," as an ordinary word is freed from all troubles (9.98–102). The Lord's happiness knew no bounds:

"With great satisfaction the Lord embraced Damodara Pandita, immersed in the bliss of divine love." (CB, Antya 9.104)

"'O Damodara, today you have bought Me, fully confirming the feeling of My heart.'" (CB, Antya 9.105)

"'All the devotion to Vishnu that I possess has come to Me by the mercy of My mother. Of this there is no doubt.'" (CB, Antya 9.106)

"'By her will I live in this world. Therefore I can never repay her for it.'" (CB, Antya 9.107)

"'O Damodara, please hear Me. I am wholly conquered by her love. I always see her.'" (CB, Antya 9.108)

Having blessed Damodara, the Lord sat down among the devotees; and He asked, Vrindavana Dasa explains, only to instruct the world (9.109–110). Murari Gupta gives the same conversation briefly:

"Once Krishna asked Sri Damodara Pandita, 'Tell Me truly: is My mother's devotion to Krishna firm?' Hearing this, he answered angrily, 'It is only by her grace that there is in You that devotion, full of the rasa of Krishna, whose nature is eternal bliss!' Hearing this, the Lord tenderly embraced the brahmana and said, 'My friend, all that you have said to Me is true. It is only by her command that I live in this Kshetra, of that there is no doubt — and yet her love draws Me back to her again and again.'" (Murari, 4.20.1–4)

Here too Damodara's anger is the same directness of love: he cannot bear even a shadow of doubt about her through whom, as he knows, Vishnu-bhakti comes into the world.

After the Lord's Concealment

The Lord counted Damodara among those associates from Bengal through whose preaching love for the holy name spread through the world:

“Acharyaratna, Acharyanidhi, Gadadhara Pandita, Jagadananda, Damodara, Shankara, Vakreshvara.” (CC, Antya 7.48)

“Kashishvara, Mukunda, Vasudeva, Murari and many other Vaishnavas were born in the land of Bengal.” (CC, Antya 7.49)

“‘All of them everywhere preach the glory of chanting the holy names of God and the enchanting beauty of love for Krishna. Thanks to them all I have understood the essence of pure devotion to Krishna.’” (CC, Antya 7.50)[15]

He outlived the Lord's concealment and remained in Navadvipa. When Narottama came there, in Mayapur he was met by the elder associates of the Lord — Shuklambara, Ishana, Murari, Damodara, Dasa Gadadhara — grieving for the Lord; “seeing Damodara Pandita there, Narottama in agitation bowed down at his feet” (“Bhakti-ratnakara” 8.93). The “Narottama-vilasa” adds that “Pandita Damodara and the others dear to Prabhu could not let Narottama go for a moment” (3.132). Srinivasa too came to Navadvipa, and there he was met by “Sri Murari, Srivasa Pandita, Damodara, Sanjaya, Vijaya, the brahmachari Shuklambara, Dasa Gadadhara and others” (“Bhakti-ratnakara” 4.57–58) — according to one of the biographies, those who told him to go to Vrindavana.

Later traditions preserve a few more touches. According to the “Anuragavalli,” after the Lord's departure only her maidservants and — “by the Lord's order” — Damodara Pandita would enter the presence of Vishnupriya, who lived in seclusion; there he is also remembered as one “impartial even towards Mahaprabhu,” who at once restores proper order, and the Ganga water for her service is carried by his servant (2.105–112); the “Advaita-prakasha” tells how Ishana, coming to Navadvipa, met Damodara Pandita and with him entered Vishnupriya's inner apartments, and later sees him dancing in Advaita's last kirtana in Shantipura (22.70–82, 22.115)[16].

When and where he left this world the sources do not say. Neither the day of his appearance nor that of his departure is named by the biographies or the primary sources; nor are they in our calendar.

Significance

Damodara Pandita entered the history of the Lord's pastimes as “the one who chastises by word.” But all his strictness comes from love: in reproaching the Lord he cares only that no one's gossip should touch His name, and the Lord Himself calls his reproaches “waves of pure love” and knows no one closer. He, by nature free from regard for people, himself acknowledges that the Lord is independent and accountable to no one — and that He is conquered by His devotee's love. The Lord's words about him had, as Srila Bhaktivinoda explains in the interpretation one of the biographies cites, a teaching meaning as well: even valuing his directness, the Lord gently showed that it too needs measure. Above all, through Damodara the Lord revealed to the world *nirapeksha*, fearless faithfulness to what is right, without which dharma cannot be protected — and therefore it was to him, and to no one else, that He entrusted His mother's house.

The world owes him the first biography of the Lord as well: from his questions grew Murari Gupta's poem, and from it Lochana Dasa's “Chaitanya-mangala.” “Hearing of them cleanses the heart of ignorance and godlessness,” says Krishnadasa Kaviraja of Damodara's vakya-danda; and Damodara

himself, having heard Murari to the end, said: “I have reached my goal.”

1. The identification follows the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” of Kavi Karnapura, a contemporary of the Lord. The “fieriness” of Shaibya and of Damodara is not worldly anger but the directness of love, which will not keep silent about anything that, to its mind, does not befit the beloved. Karnapura does not name the reason why Sarasvati, the goddess of speech, entered into Damodara.

2. The biographies speak only of Shankara. The “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” (168) names Pitambara but says nothing of his kinship with Damodara; only the “Vaishnava-vandana” considers him Damodara's elder brother. The meaning of Lochana Dasa's verse is not entirely clear.

3. One of the biographies, retelling the “Chaitanya-mangala,” writes that Lochana Dasa heard Murari's verses from Damodara Pandita, who taught them to him, and that he also heard from Damodara the stories of the “Jaimini-bharata” and of Vishvarupa's sannyasa. The “Chaitanya-mangala” itself — both in the edition of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati (1922) and in the edition of 1983 — says only that Damodara questioned Murari and that Lochana “heard” their dialogue (Sutra-khanda, pt. 1, vv. 53–56; pt. 2, v. 4; Madhya-khanda, pt. 22, vv. 252–253); both stories Lochana gives as a conversation between Murari and Damodara.

4. According to one of the biographies, it was Shachi Devi who told Damodara to accompany the Lord; according to another, the mother's request concerned only the Lord's living in Puri. According to the “Charitamrita,” it was Advaita Acharya who gave the Lord His companions.

5. The primary sources tell this differently. According to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata,” the Lord was accompanied on the road to Puri by Nityananda, Gadadhara, Mukunda, Govinda and Brahmananda, while Damodara Pandita came to Nilachala later, together with Shankara Pandita — after Svarupa Damodara and the associates from Orissa: “Also, after a couple of days, Damodara Pandita and Sri Shankara Pandita came there” (CB, Antya 3.185). According to the “Chaitanya-mangala,” the Lord set out with Gadadhara, Nityananda, Narahari, Srinivasa, Murari, Mukunda and Damodara (Madhya-khanda, pt. 20, vv. 82–83). The “Gaura-krishnodaya” and the late “Advaita-prakasha” (15.113) also name him as the Lord's companion on this road. We follow the “Charitamrita,” according to which Shankara came to Puri later, with the devotees of Bengal (Madhya 11.146).

6. Panihati and Baranagar (Varahanagara), according to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata,” the Lord visited later, when He came from Nilachala to Bengal (CB, Antya 5.75–110); the road of 1510 it traces through Atisara, Chhatrabhoga and Remuna (Antya 2.50, 2.60, 2.276). The biography has apparently merged the two journeys.

7. One of the biographies takes these two verses to be the first of the hundred verses of a hymn that Sarvabhauma composed on beholding the Lord's six-armed form, and says that Mukunda wrote them on the wall before the Lord's dwelling. According to the “Charitamrita,” the hymn of a hundred verses is a separate song (Madhya 6.257–258), and the two verses on the leaf are distinct (6.254–255).

8. Listing those in Navadvipa whom Krishnadasa's news gladdened, the “Charitamrita” names Damodara Pandita too (Madhya 10.81–84), although just before, according to the same book, he himself meets the Lord in Puri and with his friends sends Krishnadasa to Bengal (Madhya 9.340, 10.67). So it stands in the text. Perhaps this verse explains what the biographies say: later Damodara himself came from Puri to Gauda.

9. One of the biographies places this serving of prasada on the day of the Ratha-yatra, after the kirtana before the chariot; another, “after the sankirtana in Purushottama.” According to the “Charitamrita” (Madhya 12.163–164), it was the feast in the garden after the cleansing of the Gundicha temple.

10. The blow with the song-book is a play of love (*prema-lila*) of the Lord with His eternal associate. The Lord is subject neither to anger nor to any other worldly feeling; His “anger” here, like Damodara's reproaches, is one of the waves of the love that binds Him to His devotees. Karnapura himself names the cause — “out of love” (*pranayat*).

11. One of the biographies names Athara-nala, the bridge at the entrance to Puri, as the place of the meeting; according to the “Charitamrita,” the Lord was met at Narendra-sarovara.

12. One of the biographies gives the references for this and the following episodes as “Adi 3.11–12,” “Adi 3.22–23,” and below “Adi 7.50”; read Antya 3.11–12, 3.22–23 and 7.50.

13. Damodara's words are concern for the Lord's honour in the eyes of the world (*loka-apavada*, people's talk), not a suspicion of anything worldly: the Lord he himself calls independent, and the boy's mother austere and chaste. The Lord Himself willed this pastime and was pleased with it (CC, Adi 10.32; Antya 3.18–19); Damodara's vakya-danda is a manifestation of pure love, and the “Charitamrita” promises those who hear of it the cleansing of the heart (Antya 3.46).

14. The Bengali text has *nirapeksha*: “there is no one among My people as nirapeksha as you; without nirapeksha dharma cannot be protected.” One of the biographies stresses that here the Lord once more pointed to this trait of Damodara.

15. See note 12.

16. The “Anuragavalli” and the “Advaita-prakasha” are late works, and their accounts are not confirmed by the primary sources.